

Oceans in danger

The oceans once seemed too big to be affected by anything we could do to them. But a combination of pollution, overfishing, and coastal development is wrecking many marine habitats and killing their wildlife. In some parts of the world, large areas of the seabed near big cities have been turned into poisoned underwater deserts.



OVERFISHING

The modern fishing industry is so efficient that it is destroying fish populations—a big modern fishing boat can catch an entire school of fish in one net, so none of the fish can escape to breed. If this continues, there will be very few fish left to catch by 2050. Meanwhile, many seabirds, dolphins, seals, and sea turtles are being killed accidentally as they are trapped by nets and fishing lines.



SEWAGE POLLUTION

In many parts of the world, raw sewage is pumped into the ocean. This contains microbes that can cause disease. It also includes substances that fuel the growth of certain types of plankton that create toxic “red tides,” as seen here. When these die off, their decay uses up vital oxygen in the water, killing marine life.

PLAGUE OF PLASTIC

Vast amounts of garbage find their way into the oceans, and a lot of it drifts in the currents for years. Plastic in particular does not rust away or decay; it is swept up on beaches such as this one all over the world. This garbage forms deadly traps for sea life. Seals, for example, get caught in discarded, drifting fishing nets, and often drown because they cannot swim to the surface to breathe.

